

The Global Burden of Mental Illness



Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data overview | 2023

Source: Our World in Data / IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025)

Hundreds of Millions Affected: 1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression



1 in 3

women will experience
major depression in their lifetime

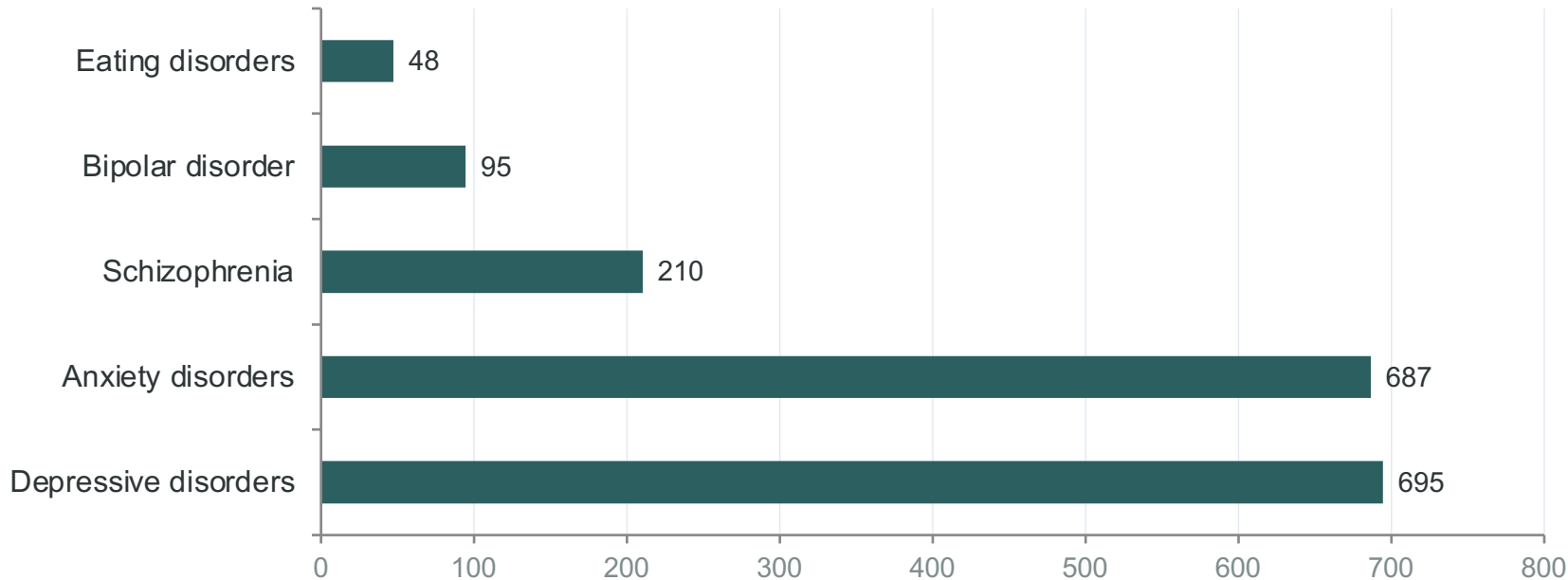


1 in 5

men will experience
major depression in their lifetime

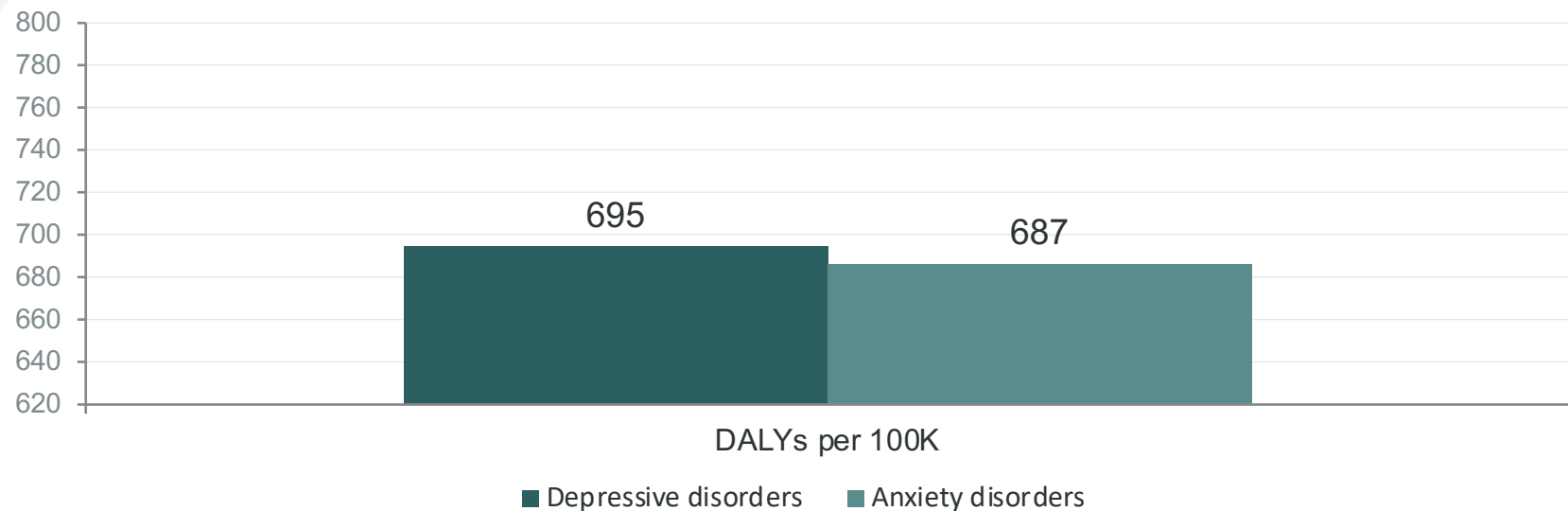
Mental health conditions span from common disorders (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe conditions (schizophrenia, bipolar disorder). Poor mental health affects well-being, work capacity, and relationships with friends, family, and community.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate: ~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively



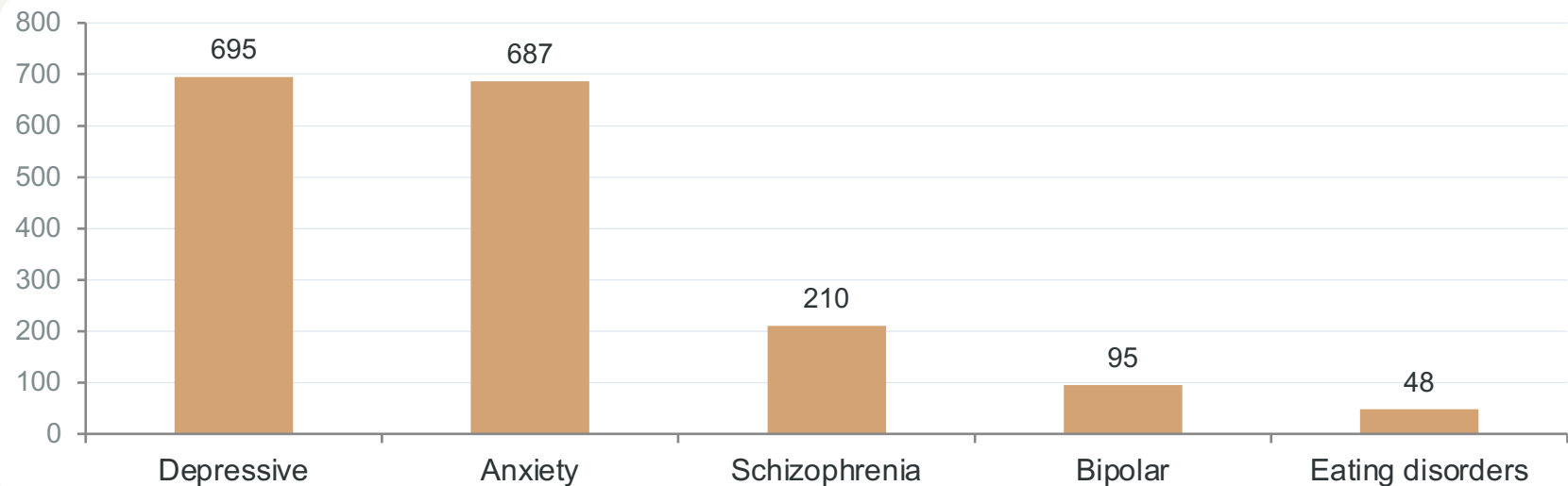
Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) via Our World in Data

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide



Together, depressive and anxiety disorders account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories.

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



Schizophrenia: 210.2 DALYs per 100K

Severe disability despite lower prevalence

Bipolar disorder: 94.6 DALYs per 100K

Smaller but meaningful individual burden

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence.

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced. The actual burden may be higher than reported figures suggest.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings as a primary treatment approach.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide as a coping mechanism.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported social support strategy across cultures.

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways: Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence.
- 3 Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate across much of the world.
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, masking the true scale of need.
- 5 Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.